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DEFINING COMPLEXITY: THE CYCLADES VS. CRETE AT THE END OF THE EARLY BRONZE AGE (c. 2800-2200 BCE)

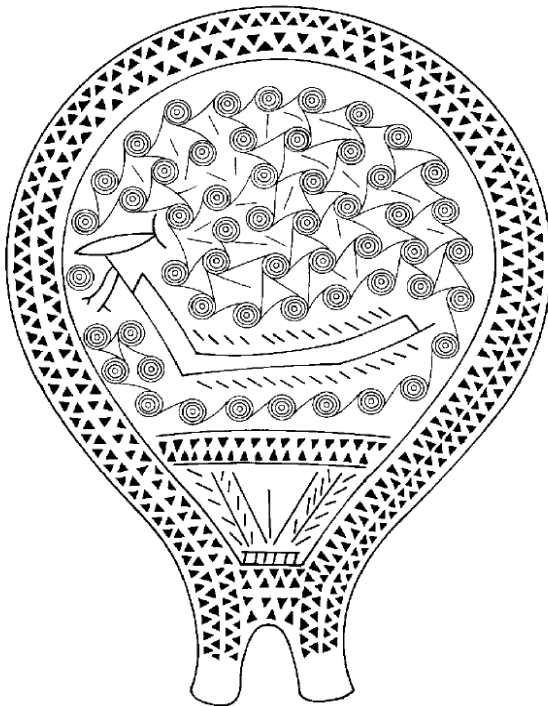
Christopher Nuttall, Uppsala universitet



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Cycladic Narrative I

- Small-scale communities
- Seafaring – longboats
- “International Spirit”¹ in EB IIA (2750 BCE)



¹ Renfrew 1972



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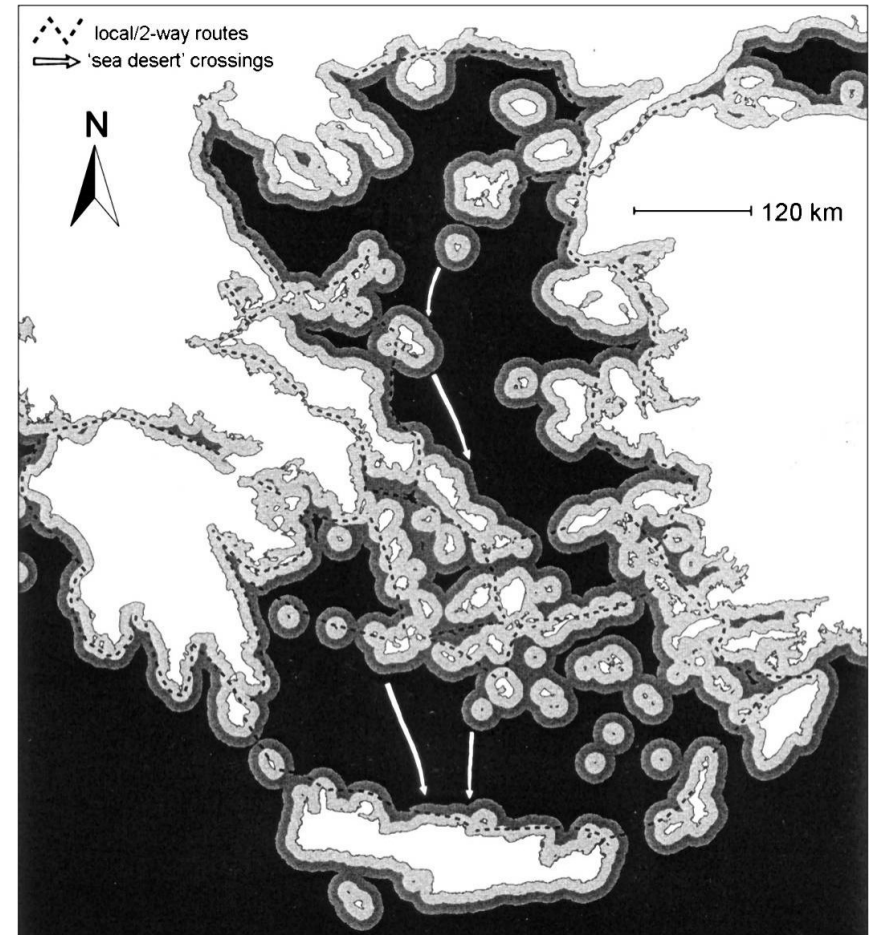
Cycladic Narrative II

- Emergence of elites?
- “Anatolianisation” in EB IIB (2500 BCE)
- Collapse of the system in EB III (2300 BCE) – sailing boats and climate change?
- System of nucleated settlements in MBA.
- Heterarchy?

1.



2.



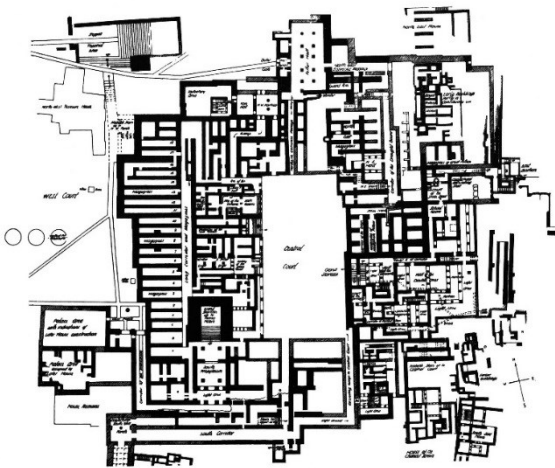
1. Doumas 1964, fig 4.

2. Broodbank 2000.



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- Narrative dominated by the appearance of “palaces” in MB IB (2000 BCE)
- Regional difference in EB I (2800 BCE)
- Inter-regional contact in EB IIA (2750 BCE)
- Population increase



Minoan Narrative I





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Minoan Narrative II

- Contact with the Near East
- Socio-political competition (mortuary in EB II, settlement in EB III, 2300 BCE)
- Hierarchisation

1.



2.

1. Seager 1904.
2. Personal photograph



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Complexity in the Aegean: Snapshot I

The Emergence of Civilisation

The Cyclades and the Aegean
in the Third Millennium BC

Colin Renfrew



- Emergence of Civilisation by Prof. Colin Renfrew (1972)
- Population growth led to surplus, technological innovations led to social change.
- Cumulative effect was the Minoan Palaces.
- Complexity vs Simplicity?
- Civilisation = Complexity
- Renfrew defines civilisation as:



Complexity in the Aegean: Snapshot II

- *“Probably no civilisation lacks the monumental public buildings...” [5], “the presence of writing is a key feature...” [6]*
- Civilisation can be found in 2 of:
 - Towns of over 5,000 population
 - Written language
 - Monumental ceremonial centres
- Non-complex societies are defined as:
- *“Associated with food production and...kinship...but the basic tribal structure is a weak one: there is no governmental organisation at tribal level and leadership is often confined in scope to the...village.”*
- While a lot has changed, the paradigm has endured.



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Defining Complexity Part I

- “Complexity” as **Social Complexity**
- Herbert Simon:



“Roughly, by a complex system I mean one made up of a large number of parts that interact in a non-simple way. In such systems, the whole is more than the sum of the parts, not in an ultimate, metaphysical sense, but in the important pragmatic sense that...”¹

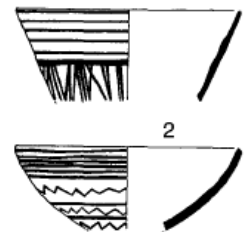
¹ Simon 1962, 468

Archaeological evidence of complexity in Crete I: EB II (2750 - 2500 BCE)

- Feasting ceremonies: Knossos and Phaistos as ancestral centres - focal point for feasting ceremonies: assemblages of pouring vessels and drinking cups.
- Architectural changes: courtyards at both Malia and Knossos in EB IIB. Restriction of access? Terracing and ramped entrances at both Knossos and Phaistos.
- Seal usage: Seals and sealings found in EB II tombs. EB II sealings at Myrtos, Trypeti and Malia.
- Emergence of elite identities?



1



2



3



4



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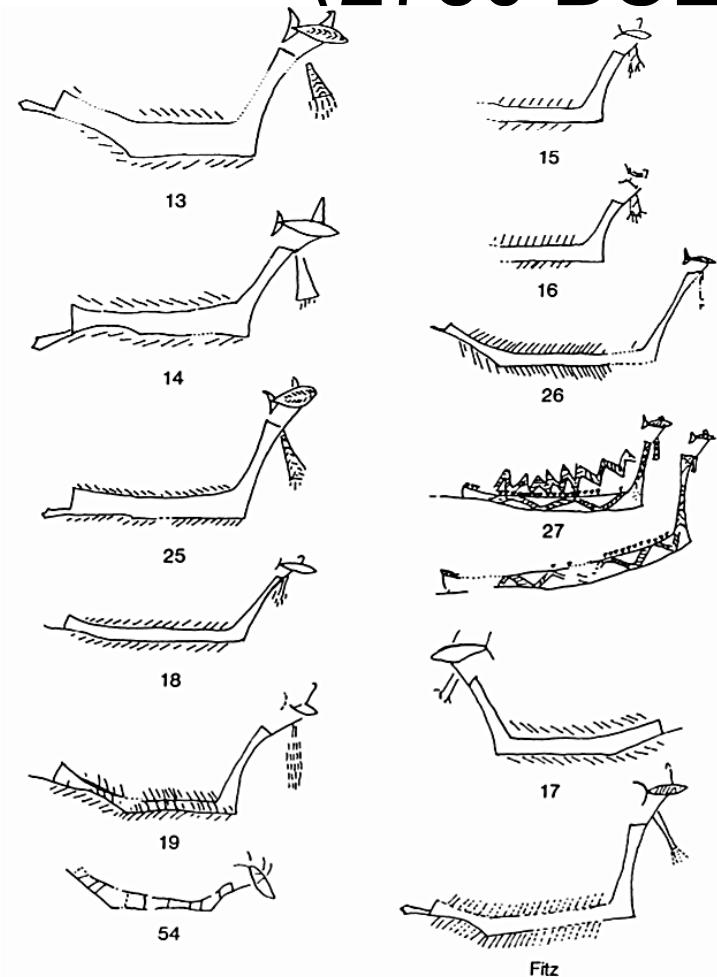
Archaeological evidence of complexity in Crete II: EB III (2300 BCE)



- Ritual usage of peak sanctuaries: Already in EB III they acquired a new significance and ritual function.
- Nucleation: population increases and emergence of small rural sites which may be linked to agricultural intensification.

Archaeological evidence of complexity in the Cyclades I: EB IIA (2750 BCE)

- Longboat seafaring: social organisation to ensure the continued survival of communities.
- Emergence of 'elites': Single burials and restriction of sailing
- Seal usage: Seals at Skarkos and Cave of Zas indicate some degree of organisation.



Archaeological evidence of complexity in the Cyclades II: EB IIB/III (2500-2300 BCE)

- Kavos Sanctuary:
 - ‘Special Deposit’
 - Non-local origin
 - Wide-range of origins
 - Social action of great significance
- Dhaskalio urban planning:
 - Central streets and drainage systems
 - Work is still ongoing
- By EB III there is abandonment, likely due to drought



Figure 4. Some of the 553 figurine fragments recovered from the Early Cycladic sanctuary at Kavos.



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Defining Complexity Part II: Discussion

- Not much difference in the “trajectories” in the two regions
- Crete interpreted via the lens of the later MB palaces
- Cyclades interpreted through the lens of a non-complex society

“...by a complex system I mean one made up of a large number of parts that interact in a non-simple way.”

- Several similarities in developments
- Differences: Scale of development and the constraints of geography
- We can see complexity everywhere if we choose to see it.
- Different circumstances led to the formation of state-level societies on Crete and not in the Cyclades.



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Thanks for your time!

Any questions?

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